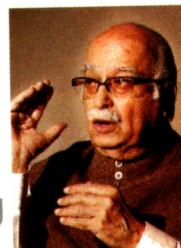




“its inaction on the Afzal case, the UPA Government has reduced the country's image to that of a soft state.”



L. K. ADVANI LEADER OF THE OPPOSITION

“Now that they are out of power, they can say anything. But what is important is what they did while in power.”



ABHISHEK SINGHVI CONGRESS SPOKESPERSON

President and that it would be a while before Afzal's is disposed of by the Rashtrapati Bhavan.

Curiously, the BJP and Afzal seem to agree on the UPA Government's lack of commitment to fight terrorism. “We have been saying from the very beginning that if Afzal is not hanged, it will send a wrong message,” says BJP spokesperson Prakash Javadekar. He brushes aside Tiwari's contention of the long pending list of mercy petitions as a lame excuse. According to him, there is no law that binds the Government to follow a first-come-first-serve principle here. He says the nature of the crime gave the Government the prerogative to prioritise a decision on Afzal's petition which it is unwilling to exercise. “It is not a post office that you have to wait in queue,” Javadekar says, “let us come back to power, we will hang him within 10 months.” The BJP doesn't come out smelling of roses either. “They can say anything when they are out of power, what matters is what they did when they were in power,” says Congress spokesperson Abhishek Manu Singhvi, accusing the BJP of chest-beating to

create a climate of jingoism.

In the week that saw perhaps the most orchestrated terror acts in the country since the Mumbai serial blasts in January 2003, ruling and Opposition politicians began to duel over the need to bring in new laws to tame the perpetrators. BJP leaders want Prevention of Terrorism Act (POTA), enacted in 2001 by the NDA and repealed by the UPA on the grounds of its misuse, to be brought back. Though states ruled by the party have passed POTA-like laws to tackle terrorism, they are still awaiting presidential assent to enforce them. This, the BJP says, is a proof of the Congress's doublespeak. Visiting the blast-affected areas of Ahmedabad last week, Advani noted that while anti-terror laws recommended by the BJP-ruled Gujarat and Rajasthan are awaiting Centre's approval, Congress-ruled Maharashtra had its own law to tackle terror, the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA).

Any law is only as good as its implementation. On anti-terror laws, sadly, the UPA Government is seen dragging its feet. ■

LONG WAIT: Afzal Guru, the main accused in Parliament attack case